First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 7
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Earth
18 October 2026

Preaching: ML
Worship Leading: LVF & Sharon Duncan
Musical Leadership: Brandon Harris

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

[CB: Below pieces are reprogrammed from my first organ prelude concert at FCCLA a mere 13 years ago :)]

Improvisation on LAUDA ANIMA and BUNESSAN

Paraphrases of two Preludes in C Major (C. Bull, after Bach)

Wer nur den lieben Gott läßt walten, BWV 647 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Wachet auf, ruft uns die Stimme, BWV 645 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Well-tempered Variations on a Bach Prelude in D minor (C. Bull, after Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura and Sharon center chancel]

Welcome **LVF**

Good morning and welcome to First Congregational Church of Los Angeles.
Each week, we give thanks for all who have gathered from near and from far
as we celebrate this life we are privileged to share.

Today we continue our creation series, Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul,
as Rev. Michael reminds us of the Sacred Earth and the Life within all Life.

So we set our intention for this day,
and ask that our souls will awake
to the words, the music, and the message
of all - this time together
will bring.

As we gather this morning,
listen to these words that call us
to consider the world around us:

Words of Gathering **SD & LVF**

SD: We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy One,
who is infinitely greater than words can express,
and yet is the Heart of our hearts,
and the Mind of our minds,
and whose love for us, and all creation,
exceeds our capacity to imagine.

LVF: We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy Oneness,
the web of life that holds all beings in intimate
embrace,
making it possible to distinguish, but never disconnect,
any part from the whole,
conferring kinship
in the kin-dom of God.

SD: We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the I Am-ness
that was and is and always shall be before our face;
before we were born, before the glorious becoming began.

Both: ***In devotion, we open to you,***
Great Thou of all creation.
In awe, we open to the Great Unity.
In humility, we open to the Great I Am. [adapt/bsanguin]

LVF: May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

SD: ***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.***

Hymn of Gathering** ***Praise with Joy the World's Creator **LAUDA ANIMA**

Praise with joy the world's Creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise to Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upsets religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.
Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride.

Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide,
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in community.
Calling Christians to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness** **LVF**

Holy One, it is in the depths of life that we find you,
at the heart of this moment,
at the center of our soul,
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.
You are the Ground of all being,
the Well-Spring of all time,
Womb of the earth,
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait,
not for blessings from afar,
but for You,
the very Soil of our soul,
the early Freshness of morning,
the first Breath of Day.
Amen and Amen! [JPhilipNewell]

***Introit** I am the Earth Täht and Valjayaga
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

[Sharon to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer** **SD**

Our Holy Scriptures tell us that we are all created in the image and likeness of God.
In this place, we celebrate the Mystery of who God is. We remember that our tradition is rich in calling The Divine by many names: Amma, Abba, Loving Mother, Compassionate Father, Source of Life, Redeemer, Loving Presence, Holy One, Adonai…

Because of this Mystery, we invite you to pray The Lord's Prayer
in your own tradition and language. In this way, we celebrate the interconnectedness of our lives, whether we come from near or from far.

Let us now pray together as Jesus taught us…

Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kin-dom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kin-dom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **LVF**
In the center of the whirlwind lies an eye.
Still. Open. Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries, no storms, only peace.
As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must, may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home. [adapt/lvf]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Sharon to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition ***from Exodus*** **SD**

Hear now these words from the Book of Exodus in the Hebrew Bible…

Moses was tending the flock of his father-in-law Jethro, the priest of Midian. Leading the flock deep into the wilderness, Moses came to Horeb, the mountain of God. The messenger of YHWH appeared to Moses in a blazing fire from the midst of a thornbush. Moses saw-- "The bush is ablaze with fire, and yet it isn't consumed." Moses said, "Let me go over and look at this remarkable sight-- and see why the bush doesn't burn up."

When YHWH saw Moses coming to look more closely, God called out to him from the midst of the bush, "Moses, Moses!" Moses answered, "Here I am." God said, "Come no closer. Remove the sandals from your feet, for the place where you stand is holy ground."

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph short transition Laura center chancel]
CB note to self: as per LVF, favor 'nature sounds' (Wind Chimes)

Prayers with the People **LVF**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts
Holy One,
we acknowledge
that you are a Power, a Presence
within us
within all people.
You are a creative, energizing Presence,
bonding everything that exists
through patterns of attraction and co-operation,
in an endless movement
toward new possibilities,

creating an interrelational universe
that makes human life possible.

Conscious of your Divine presence
within and among us,
we can open ourselves to new possibilities.
We can expand our minds,
embrace change,
take risks,
and boldly discard what no longer gives meaning to life,
as we deepen our awareness and appreciation
of your Presence emerging in us.

We give you thanks for the wonderful gift
of conscious awareness.
We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with your energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and care for planet Earth.

To all that is - in this time and place,
and to all that can be through the power
of your Presence within all things,
we offer ourselves to bring your dream
for this world to fruition. Amen and Amen.

[mmoorwood/adaptlvf]

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem Gather at the River Stacey V. Gibbs
Laude, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon ***Sacred Earth*** **ML**

[Christoph transition Sharon to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity **SD**

Each week we come into this sacred space
and give thanks for the wonderful gift of reflective awareness
that allows us to recognize and name the presence
of the Creative Spirit beyond all imagining in our universe.

Everything we have,
everything we see,
everything we do,
everyone we love and everyone who loves us
reveals this Illuminating Presence
and our bonds with each other
that reach across the globe.

We are so grateful that together, in this place and time, we are on the way to something unknown, something new, as we reimagine our faith, a faith that is grounded and centered in the presence of our Good and Gracious God, who loves us more than we can imagine.

Today, we invite your offerings for our Community Gardens & Urban Farm here at the Cathedral. These spaces across our 5-acre campus have been intentionally transformed for the growing and sharing of food with our beloved neighbors across Koreatown and Westlake. This food, chosen specifically for the culinary traditions of our neighbors, includes: over 60 fruit trees, a medicinal, culinary, and butterfly garden with herbs for cooking, healing, and struggling Monarch populations, and over 30 raised beds containing varieties of greens and healthy vegetables.

Our Gardens & Farm also serve as educational spaces for local area schools and organizations like HOLA, and are more frequently being used as space for nurturing spirituality, community, and reconnection with the beloved earth.

Thank you for joining us in this expansive vision, as we become the best neighbors we can be in our neighborhood. You will find a QR Code for online giving in your programs and appearing on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward to receive any gifts.

Offertory Anthem When Our Dreams Take Flight Music: Dr. Rollo Dilworth
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor* Text:Paul Laurence Dunbar

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Sharon to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer** **SD**
Holy One, as your life flows through the rivers and streams of this earth,
remind us on this day, that your life also flows through us.
With these offerings we offer our thanks and praise
and ask that the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness
move freely in our words and actions.
Awaken in us, the possibility of new life, new vision,
and renewed meaning and purpose
as we follow in the steps of those
whose faith continues to flow
around us, among us, and within us.

Thanks be to you, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church **ML & LVF**
ML: Thanks, Grace and Greg, for sponsoring today's Coffee Hour in honor of our Deacons!

LVF: Gardens & Farm tour today! Meet Laurie at the Gardens Table at Coffee Hour in Mayflower.

ML: Also giving thanks for our Food@First team today, setting the tables of community, sharing, and food with our neighbors.

LVF: Events this week: Men's Group (Wed) & Not Your Grandma's Bible Study (Thurs)

ML: Fall Festival next Sunday, October 25! Chili signups!

LVF: Encourage, as we always do, to educate ourselves on the issues for the upcoming election, mindful that some, like the PRK Charter, are consequential for our city's parks and natural spaces.

ML: Invite Laurie up:
+Introducing Emma Phillips, our new Farm Manager!

Words of Blessing **ML**

May the deep blessings of earth be with us.
May the fathomless soundings of seas surge in souls.
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths
to open us to wonder
to strengthen us for love
to humble us with gratitude
that we may find ourselves in one another
that we may lose ourselves in gladness
that we may give ourselves to peace.

Choral Response Way Over in Beulah Lan Stacey V. Gibbs
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

Hymn for the Journey** ***Come, See the Fullness **BUNESSAN**

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Short Fugue in C Major (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music- Brandon Harris

Today, as we reflect on the theme of **Sacred Earth**, we are invited to consider our relationship with the Earth, our responsibility to one another, and the holiness that surrounds us.

We begin with Täht and Valjayaga's *I Am the Earth*, a musical expression of our personal connection to the ground beneath our feet. When we recognize the Earth as an extension of ourselves, we are called to care for it with the same tenderness, respect, and love we would offer our own bodies. In embracing this shared responsibility, our individual acts of care become a collective expression of reverence for the sacred world we have been given.

Laude presents Stacey V. Gibbs' arrangement of *Gather at the River*, a song that evokes the biblical imagery of the River of Life. Rivers sustain the Earth, nourish its inhabitants, and remind us of the life-giving resources upon which our existence depends. As we gather at the river in song, we are invited to reflect on the ways these sacred waters sustain not only our physical lives but also our spiritual journeys through a world that is both beautiful and complex.

Rollo Dilworth's *When Our Dreams Take Flight*, inspired by Paul Laurence Dunbar's poem "Dreams," explores the fragile yet enduring nature of our hopes and ambitions. Through vivid images drawn from the natural world, including rosy clouds and withering flowers, Dunbar reflects on the vulnerability of dreams and the sorrow that can accompany their loss. Dilworth's warm, accessible Gospel harmonies offer a message of hope: when we come together in community, we can encourage one another, nurture our aspirations, and help one another's dreams take flight.

Finally, the Cathedral Choir offers an excerpt from Gibbs' *Way Over in Beulah Lan*, a powerful expression of the longing for a promised land of freedom, peace, and joy. For some, this land represents the heavenly home toward which we journey; for others, it inspires a vision of liberation and wholeness that we can begin to realize here on Earth. Through our commitment to justice, our care for creation, and our love for one another, we participate in making this sacred ground a place where freedom and joy can flourish.

As we listen, may the music awaken us to the holiness of the Earth beneath our feet. Like Moses before the burning bush, may we pause in reverence, recognize the divine presence in the world around us, and remember that this sacred ground is both a gift to cherish and a responsibility to uphold.